Seeing the Economy through Colored Glasses: Partisanship in Macro and (not in) Micro Expectations

Kyung Woong Koh[1], Adrian Monninger[1], and Tao Wang[2]

[1]Johns Hopkins University

[2]Bank of Canada

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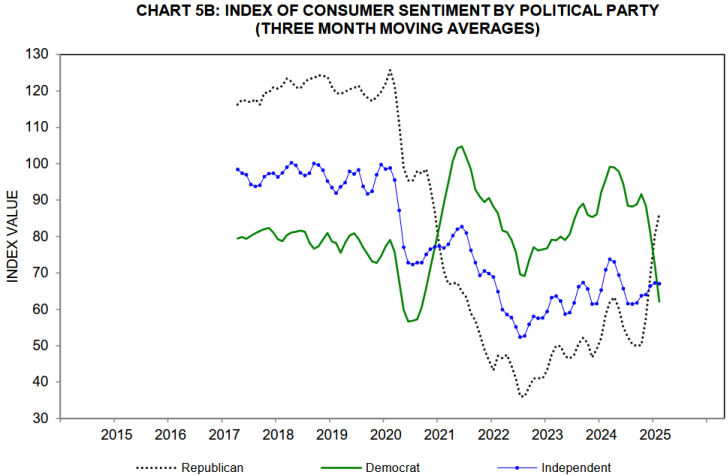
University of Ottawa

Disclaimer: views expressed in this paper are solely those of the authors instead of their respective institutions.

Motivation: partisanship in survey expectations of the macroeconomy

- U.S. households' macro expectations saw partisan switches around presidential turnovers



Partisan expectations have actual economic consequences

Partisan differences are shown to have impacts on

- Regional heterogeneity in inflation expectations (Binder, 2023)
- Perceptions of central bank credibility (Kuang *et al.*, 2024)
- Perceived causes of inflation (Stantcheva, 2024)
- Stock investments (Meeuwis *et al.*, 2022)
- ...

Also cited as a contributor to the post-COVID "vibecession" (Paul Krugman, Evans (2025); Cummings & Mahoney (2023), etc)

This paper

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2. Show that micro expectations exhibit less partisanship than macro expectations
3. Distinguish between bias, sentiment, and belief extrapolation
4. Use a factor model of beliefs to assess time variation
5. Show self-interest considerations in the perceived effects of policies on the macroeconomy

The main message

Partisanship does affect macroeconomic expectations ("the colored glasses"), but personal finance and self-interest reasons ("the reality") remain the anchor of household macroeconomic expectations.

Outline

1. Introduction
2. Data and Methodology
3. Graphical Evidence
4. Reduced-form evidence
5. Structural Model
6. Policy Expectations
7. Conclusion

Data

1. Household Expectations
   - New York Fed Survey of Consumer Expectations (SCE): 3 elections since 2016
   - Michigan Survey of Consumers (MSC): 12 elections since 1980
2. Party Affiliation
   - Directly reported party affiliation in MSC (only available since 2016)
   - Augmented with *imputed* affiliations based on actual vote profile estimated from the American National Election Study (ANES) for 1980-2024 elections

Empirical methodology: imputing the party affiliation

- Estimating voter profiles in ANES for each election in year y:

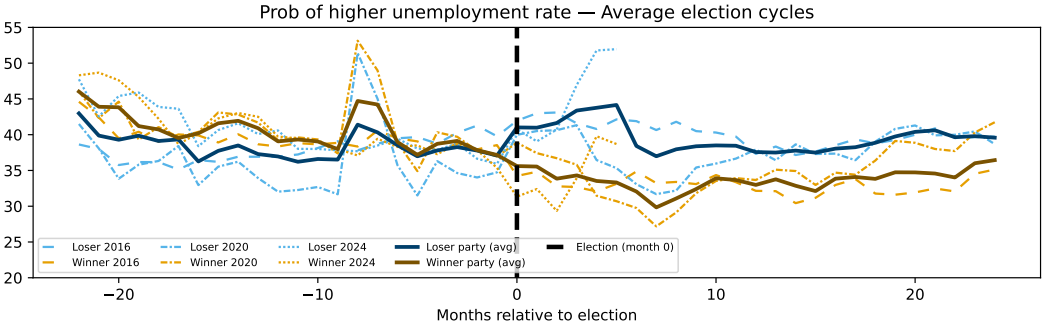
$$\Pr(\kappa_{it} = p \mid X_i) \;=\; \Phi\left(X_i' \beta_p^{(y)}\right), \qquad p \in \{\mathrm{D}, \mathrm{R}\}, \quad t = y$$

- Imputing the affiliation in MSC/SCE for the 4-year window of the same election

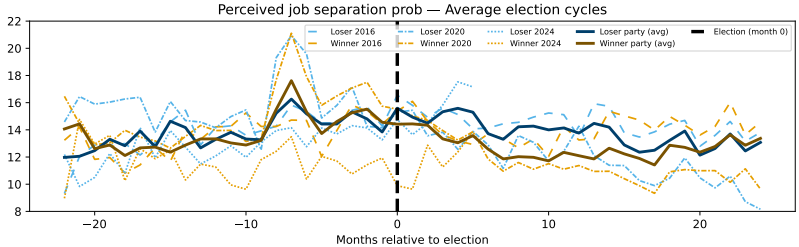
$$\hat{\kappa}_{i,t} = \begin{cases} D, & \text{if } \widehat{Pr}(\kappa_{i,t} = D|X_i) > \widehat{Pr}(\kappa_{i,t} = R|X_i), \\ R, & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases} \qquad t \in \{t-1, \ldots, t+2\}$$

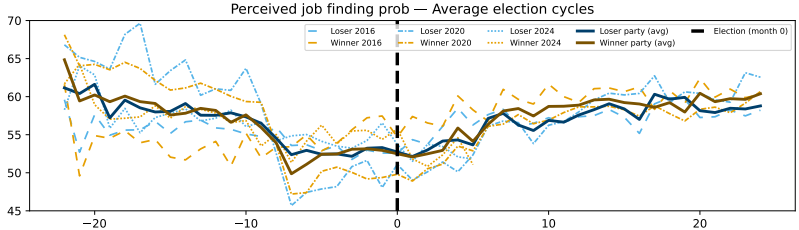
- $\Phi(\cdot)$: standard normal CDF
- $X_i = \{educ, income, gender, region, married, etc\}$
- β^y captures time-varying voter profile
- Machine learning models (random forest or XGBoost) yield similar performances

Macro beliefs (unemployment rate) show partisan switches around turnovers

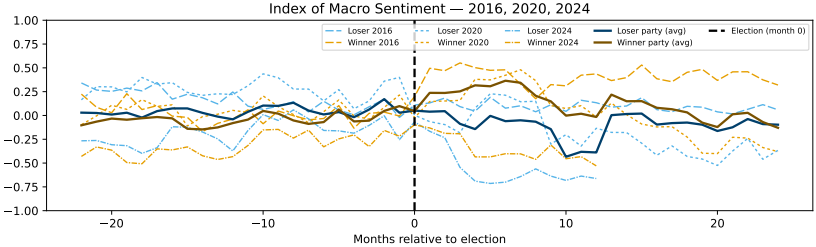


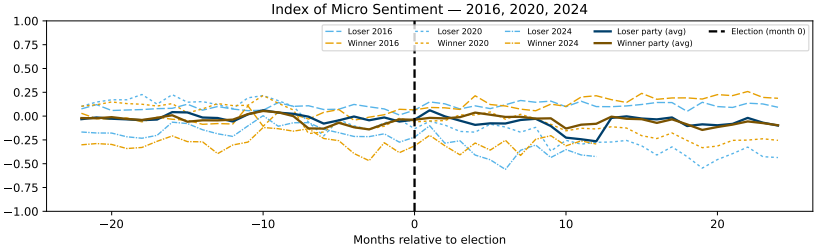
Micro beliefs (job separation and finding rate) **didn't** switch around turnover



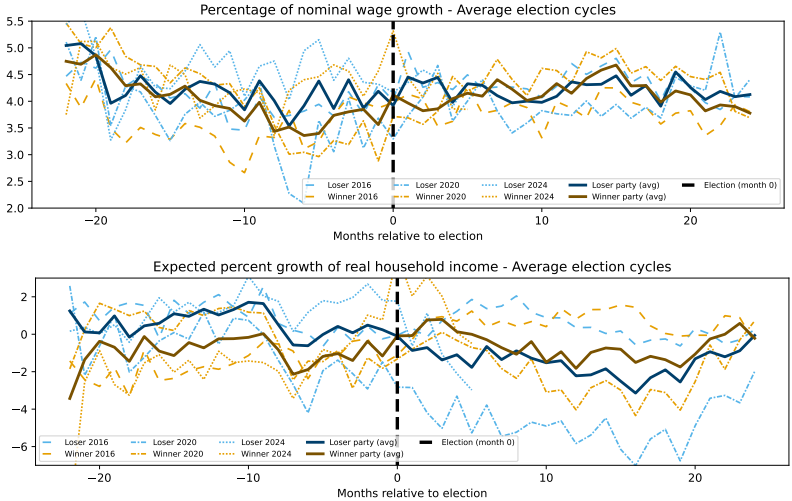


Macro vs *micro* indicators from MSC by party

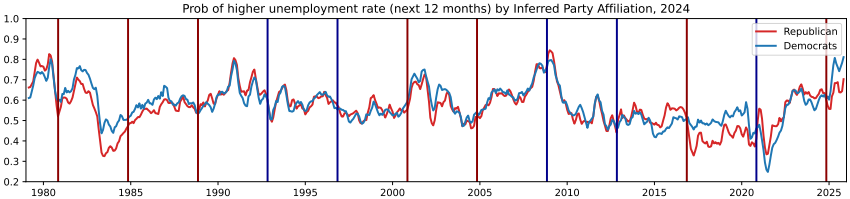




No partisan shifts in nominal wage/income expectations



Partisan expectations, 1980-2022



(a) Unemployment rate, 1980-2022

Partisan expectations, 1980-2022

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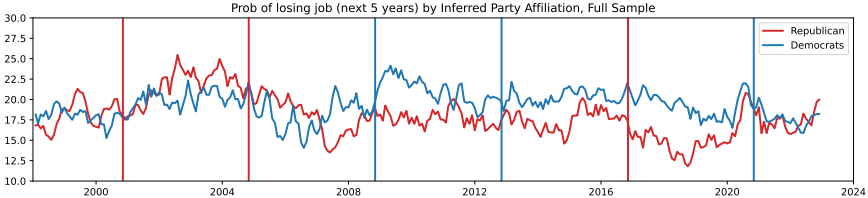

(b) Probability of losing job, 1998-2022

Partisan bias, sentiment, and extrapolation

- We differentiate between:
  1. partisan bias in average expectations
     - e.g., one party is consistently more pessimistic than the other
  2. political sentiment in expectations after month (November) of presidential election
     - e.g., the winning (losing) party is more optimistic (pessimistic) than the other
  3. belief extrapolation from micro to macro expectations
     - e.g., the winning and losing party "interprets" the same information differently

Partisan bias, sentiment, and extrapolation - specification

- We quantify the partisan bias and sentiment by running panel regressions for individual i and month t for each election cycle

$$\begin{aligned}\text{MacroBelief}_{it} = \alpha_0 &+ \alpha_1 \text{Party}_i + \alpha_2 \text{PostElect}_t \\ &+ \alpha_3 \text{Party}_i \times \text{PostElect}_t + \alpha_4 \text{MicroBelief}_{it} \\ &+ \alpha_5 \text{PostElect}_t \times \text{MicroBelief}_{it} \\ &+ \alpha_6 \text{Party}_i \times \text{MicroBelief}_{it} + \alpha_7 \text{Party}_i \times \text{PostElect}_t \times \text{MicroBelief}_{it} \\ &+ \text{Controls}_i + \varepsilon_{it}\end{aligned}$$

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- $\alpha_1 \neq 0$ implies partisan bias in beliefs $Belief_{it}$
- $\alpha_3 \neq 0$ implies partisan sentiment in beliefs after the election ($PostElect_t = 1$)
- $\alpha_6, \alpha_7 \neq 0$ imply partisan differences in belief extrapolation

Partisan bias, sentiment, and extrapolation - results

	SCE Unemp	SCE Unemp (Micro=Job Sep)	SCE Unemp (Micro=Job Find)	MSC Macro Index	MSC Micro Index (Micro=Micro Index)
Win					
postElect					
Win × postElect					
Micro					
Micro × postElect					
Micro × Win					
Micro × Win × postElect					
Controls	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Adj. R^2	0.023	0.057	0.024	0.064	0.208
N	106395	63862	63882	56115	56115

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Partisan bias, sentiment, and extrapolation - results

	SCE Unemp	SCE Unemp (Micro=Job Sep)	SCE Unemp (Micro=Job Find)	MSC Macro Index	MSC Micro Index (Micro=Micro Index)
Win	0.084				
	(0.101)				
postElect	-4.848***				
	(0.043)				
Win × postElect	-7.168***				
	(0.249)				
Micro					
Micro × postElect					
Micro × Win					
Micro × Win × postElect					
Controls	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
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Partisan bias, sentiment, and extrapolation - results

	SCE Unemp	SCE Unemp (Micro=Job Sep)	SCE Unemp (Micro=Job Find)	MSC Macro Index	MSC Micro Index (Micro=Micro Index)
Win	0.084	0.259	1.510**		
	(0.101)	(0.364)	(0.734)		
postElect	-4.848***	-4.709***	-8.180***		
	(0.043)	(0.112)	(0.372)		
Win × postElect	-7.168***	-7.769***	-7.993***		
	(0.249)	(0.549)	(0.410)		
Micro					
Micro × postElect					
Micro × Win					
Micro × Win × postElect					
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Micro		0.223***	-0.041***		
		(0.002)	(0.006)		
Micro × postElect		0.022***	0.052***		
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Micro × Win					
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Micro × postElect		0.022***	0.052***		
		(0.004)	(0.006)		
Micro × Win		-0.010	-0.024*		
		(0.016)	(0.014)		
Micro × Win × postElect					
Controls	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
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Win × postElect	-7.168***	-7.769***	-7.993***		
	(0.249)	(0.549)	(0.410)		
Micro		0.223***	-0.041***		
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Micro × postElect		0.022***	0.052***		
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Micro × Win		-0.010	-0.024*		
		(0.016)	(0.014)		
Micro × Win × postElect		0.064***	0.019*		
		(0.012)	(0.011)		
Controls	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Adj. R^2	0.023	0.057	0.024	0.064	0.208
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Partisan bias, sentiment, and extrapolation - results

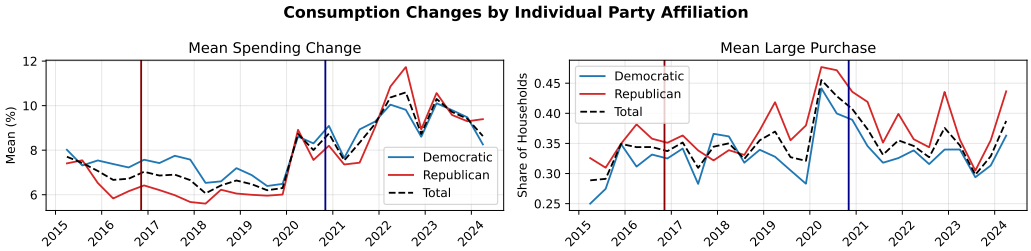
	SCE Unemp	SCE Unemp (Micro=Job Sep)	SCE Unemp (Micro=Job Find)	MSC Macro Index	MSC Micro Index (Micro=Micro Index)
Win	0.084	0.259	1.510**	-1.420	7.081
	(0.101)	(0.364)	(0.734)	(8.688)	(10.628)
postElect	-4.848***	-4.709***	-8.180***	-26.908***	7.862
	(0.043)	(0.112)	(0.372)	(1.138)	(7.110)
Win × postElect	-7.168***	-7.769***	-7.993***	42.057**	27.736
	(0.249)	(0.549)	(0.410)	(17.654)	(17.022)
Micro		0.223***	-0.041***		0.928***
		(0.002)	(0.006)		(0.069)
Micro × postElect		0.022***	0.052***		-0.145**
		(0.004)	(0.006)		(0.059)
Micro × Win		-0.010	-0.024*		-0.077
		(0.016)	(0.014)		(0.111)
Micro × Win × postElect		0.064***	0.019*		0.037
		(0.012)	(0.011)		(0.113)
Controls	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Adj. R^2	0.023	0.057	0.024	0.064	0.208
N	106395	63862	63882	56115	56115

Full Tables News

Controlling for the role of macro news

	MSC Unemp	MSC Job Separation	MSC Macro Index	MSC Micro Index
Win	-0.005	0.002	-1.420	5.288
	(0.027)	(0.021)	(8.688)	(7.113)
postElect	-0.039***	-0.033***	-26.908***	6.609**
	(0.003)	(0.002)	(1.138)	(2.873)
WinXpostElect	-0.131***	-0.118***	42.057**	35.086**
	(0.050)	(0.037)	(17.654)	(14.067)
Micro		0.148***		0.780***
		(0.020)		(0.033)
MicroXpostElect		-0.038		-0.142***
		(0.024)		(0.025)
MicroXWin		-0.029		-0.058
		(0.038)		(0.086)
MicroXWinXpostElect		-0.043		-0.081
		(0.038)		(0.090)
News		-0.142***		42.805***
		(0.018)		(3.757)
NewsXpostElect		0.035*		-2.461
		(0.019)		(3.715)
NewsWin		0.024**		-1.171
		(0.011)		(1.842)
NewsXWinXpostElect		-0.055***		12.120***
		(0.011)		(1.953)
Controls	YES	YES	YES	YES
Adj. R^2	0.052	0.086	0.064	0.275
N	56115	56115	56115	56115

No sudden switch in actual spending patterns around turnovers



- Naturally explained by the non-divergence in micro expectations
- suggesting that micro expectations are better inputs for one's consumption spending decisions

A factor model of beliefs

- Household i has a given partisan preferences $\kappa_{i,t} \in \{D, R\}$

A factor model of beliefs

- Household i has a given partisan preferences $\kappa_{i,t} \in \{D, R\}$
- $\kappa_{i,t}$ and $\Theta_t \in \{D, R\}$ the incumbent party determine i's political sentiment $x_{i,t}$

$$x_{i,t} = \mathbf{1}(\kappa_{i,t} = D)\mathbf{1}(\Theta_t = D) + \mathbf{1}(\kappa_{i,t} = R)\mathbf{1}(\Theta_t = R)$$

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- $x_{i,t}$ and $s_{i,t}$ determine i's macro expectations $z_{i,t}$ through functions z^{up} and z^{down}

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- $x_{i,t}$ and $s_{i,t}$ determine i's macro expectations $z_{i,t}$ through functions z^{up} and z^{down}

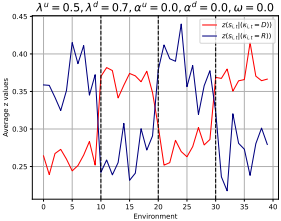
$$z(s_{i,t}, \kappa_{i,t}, x_{i,t}) = \underbrace{\mathbf{1}(\kappa_{i,t} = D)\omega}_{\text{partisan bias}} + \mathbf{1}(x_{i,t} = 1) \underbrace{z^{up}(s_{i,t})}_{=\alpha^{up}+\lambda^{up}s_{i,t}} + \mathbf{1}(x_{i,t} \neq 1) \underbrace{z^{down}(s_{i,t})}_{=\alpha^{down}+\lambda^{down}s_{i,t}}$$

$$+ \zeta_i + \phi_t + \varepsilon_{i,t}$$

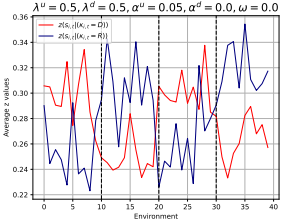
- $\alpha^{up}; \alpha^{down}$: sentiment shift
- $\lambda^{up}; \lambda^{down}$: extrapolation

Model mechanisms behind the expectation shift around an election turnover

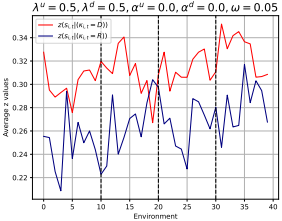
Figure: Group-specific macroeconomic expectations simulated under different parameter values



(a) $\lambda^{up} \neq \lambda^{down}$



(b) $\alpha^{up} \neq \alpha^{down}$



(c) $\alpha^{up} = \alpha^{down}$, $\lambda^{up} = \lambda^{down}$

- Either $\lambda^{up} \neq \lambda^{down}$ or $\alpha^{up} \neq \alpha^{down}$ can generate partisan switching around turnovers

Modeling mislabeling

- Our partisanship flag $\hat{\kappa}_{i,t}$ is only a noisy and potentially mis-labeled measure of the true type $\kappa_{i,t}$
- We model the labeling error explicitly

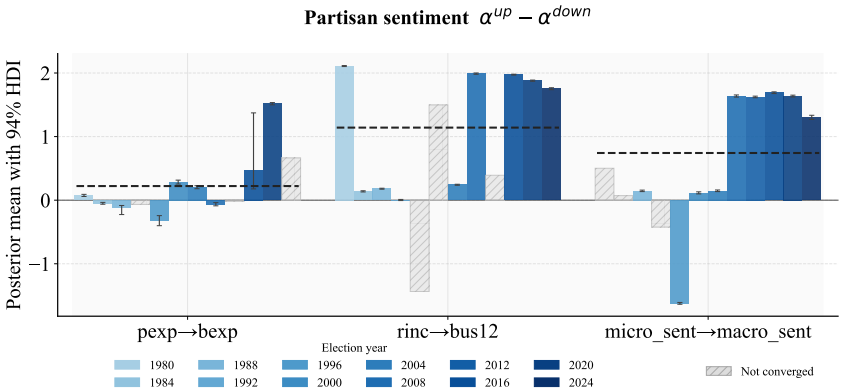
$$\kappa_{i,t} \sim \text{Bernoulli}(p)$$

- Define false-negative and false-positive rates as

$$e_1 = P(\hat{\kappa}_{i,t} = R \mid \kappa_{i,t} = D), \qquad e_0 = P(\hat{\kappa}_{i,t} = D \mid \kappa_{i,t} = R).$$

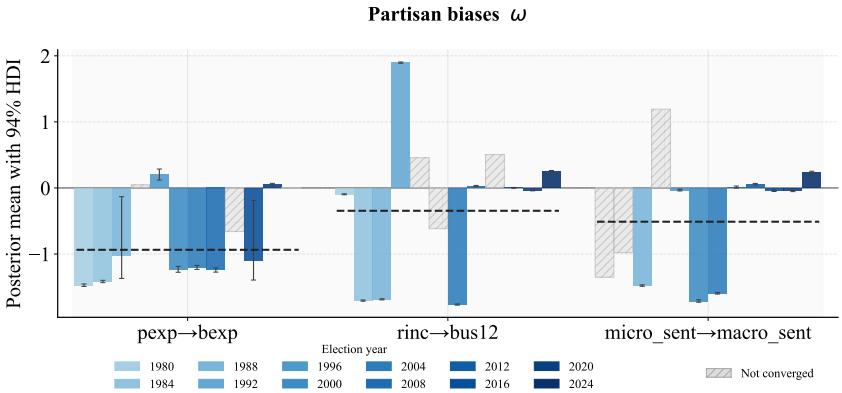
- We estimate belief parameters $\Gamma = [\lambda^{up}, \lambda^{down}, \alpha^{up}, \alpha^{down}, \omega]$ and p, e_0, e_1 jointly using Bayesian methods

Estimation result: sentiment shift ($\alpha^{up} - \alpha^{down}$)



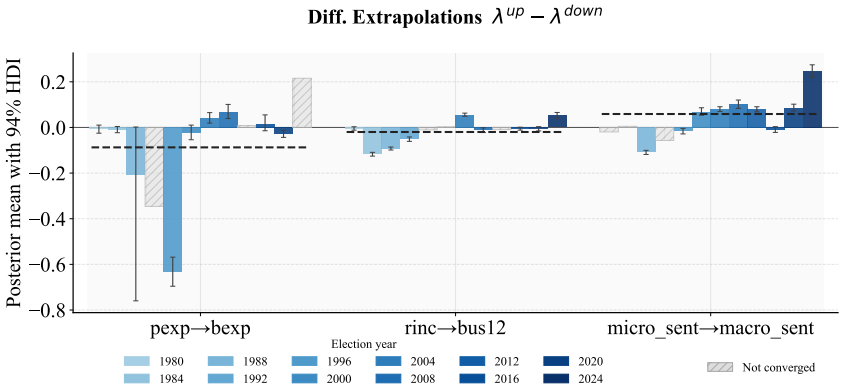
⟹ A positive sentiment drift for the incumbent party

Estimation result: partisan bias (ω)



$\Longrightarrow$ Democrats are more pessimistic

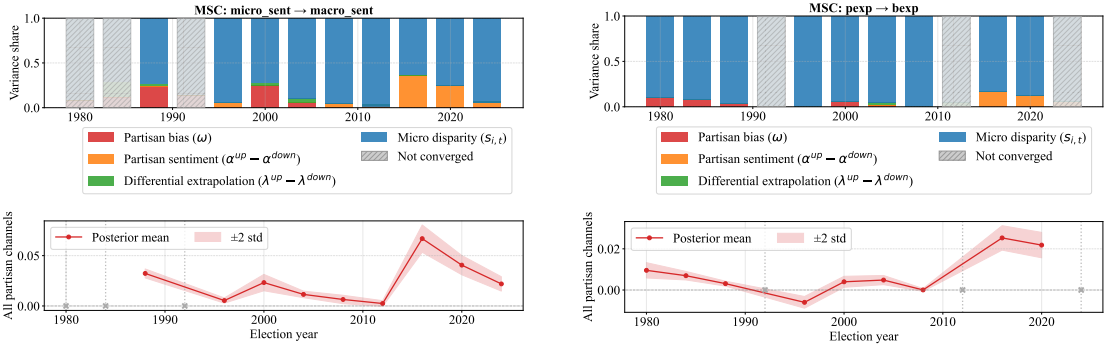
Estimation result: extrapolations ($\lambda^{up} - \lambda^{down}$)



⟹ Different extrapolations between the incumbent and opposition parties

Time-varying importance of partisanship versus micro disparity

- The fraction of macroeconomic expectation variation explained by our model

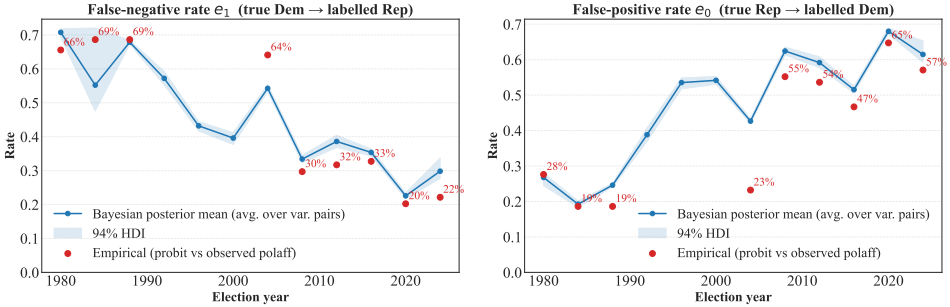


⟹ Partisanship was not a new phenomenon

⟹ But the recent 3 election since 2016 did see intensified partisan patterns

An external validation: model-implied error rates versus actual

Probit mislabel rates: Bayesian estimates vs empirical (MSC, partisan respondents only)



- Model estimates of the error rates match closely with the actual error rates
- The model increasingly over-classifies individuals as Democrats

Role of policy expectations - questions

- Households hold partisan views of the economy
- Is it because they hold partisan expectations on public policy?

  Partisans may expect better economy because their preferred policies are enacted

- We use data from SCE's Public Policy Survey (PPS) sub-module
  - on households' expectations on expansion/reduction(+1/-1) of 6 public policies[1]
  - and effects of policy on own household (not the general public)

[1] Welfare benefits, payroll tax increase, unemployment benefits, capital gains tax, income tax, and income tax for the highest income bracket.

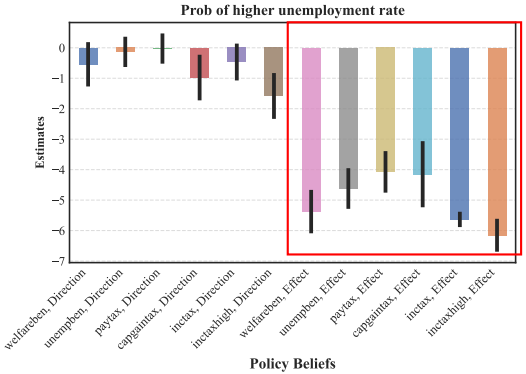
Role of policy expectations - self-interest hypothesis

- We test the hypothesis that households' macro beliefs improve when their preferred policies are enacted
- We run regression on SCE data across 2016 and 2020 elections:

$$\text{Belief}_{it} = \alpha_0 + \alpha_1 \text{PolicyDirection}_{jit} + \alpha_2 \text{PolicyEffect}_{jit} + \textit{Controls}_i + \varepsilon_{it}$$

- α_1 indicates the expected impacts on the macroeconomy by a given policy change
- α_2 indicates change in households' beliefs based on expected effects of policy
  - $\uparrow$ PolicyEffect $\implies$ $\uparrow$ Personal benefit

Role of policy expectations - results



- Expectations of a higher unemployment rate in 12 months
- Left half: α_1's, right half: α_2's
- Effects are highly significant for α_2, i.e. for PolicyEffect$_{jit}$

$\Longrightarrow$ Households believe policies that are beneficial to them as beneficial to the entire economy

Role of policy expectations - more results

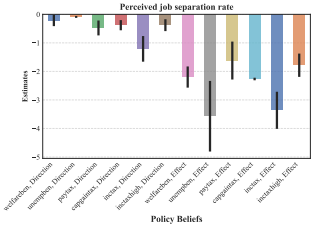


Figure: Job Separation Rate

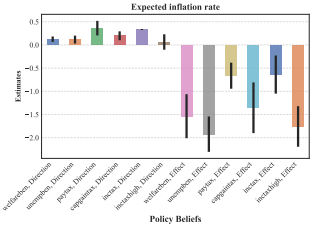


Figure: Inflation Rate

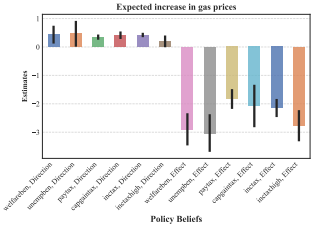


Figure: Gas Prices

- Across all policies, expecting personal benefits from a given policy is associated with more positive macroeconomic expectations.

Partisan cheerleading?

- Do households always perceive the policies of their favored president to be good for the macroeconomy?
- Not often the case: no to weak evidence on such cheerleading effects
- But they perceive the policies of their favored party to benefit themselves

Extension: colored glasses beyond the partisan affiliation

- $\kappa_{i,t}$ does not have to be D or R
- Rather, it can be any assortive sorting with D or R
  - e.g., if low income (L) supports D while high income (H) supports R

$$x_{i,t} = \mathbf{1}(\kappa_{i,t} = L)\mathbf{1}(\Theta_t = D) + \mathbf{1}(\kappa_{i,t} = H)\mathbf{1}(\Theta_t = R)$$

- Such sorting might change over time
- The sorting factor does not have to be economic
  - e.g., ideological views on social issues
- Such belief distortions can be explained by motivated beliefs(Brunnermeier & Parker, 2005; Zimmermann, 2020) or the "echo chamber"(Cookson *et al.*, 2023), etc.

Conclusion

- We show that household macro beliefs are more partisan than micro beliefs
- We differentiate between:
  1. Partisan bias
  2. Political sentiment
  3. Belief extrapolation
- Our model shows how partisanship differs over time
- We highlight the central role of personal economic experiences
- **Partisanship does not overrule personal finance's role in macroeconomic expectations**

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Real household income expectations

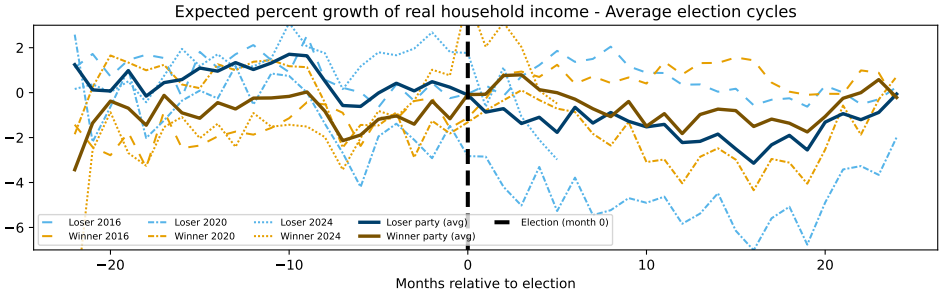

Figure: Mean expected percentage of real household income growth by party, individual-level data Back

Partisan Bias, Sentiment, and Extrapolation - Additional Results (I)

	MSC macro	MSC micro	MSC bexp	MSC pexp	MSC bus12	MSC rinc	SCE	SCE Job Sep	SCE Job Find
Win	-0.769	7.973	0.013	-0.008	-0.002	-0.001	0.084	0.259	1.510**
	(8.446)	(10.329)	(0.027)	(0.026)	(0.044)	(0.033)	(0.101)	(0.364)	(0.734)
postElect	-27.385***	7.644	-0.053***	-0.047***	-0.134***	-0.100***	-4.848***	-4.709***	-8.180***
	(1.059)	(6.531)	(0.003)	(0.004)	(0.005)	(0.005)	(0.043)	(0.112)	(0.372)
WinXpostElect	41.326**	27.209	0.170***	0.176***	0.189**	0.215***	-7.168***	-7.769***	-7.993***
	(17.235)	(16.583)	(0.047)	(0.060)	(0.088)	(0.071)	(0.249)	(0.549)	(0.410)
Micro		0.927***		0.384***		0.314***		0.223***	-0.041***
		(0.064)		(0.004)		(0.009)		(0.002)	(0.006)
MicroXpostElect		-0.145***		0.063***		0.000		0.022***	0.052***
		(0.053)		(0.005)		(0.004)		(0.004)	(0.006)
MicroXWin		-0.082		0.032		0.002		-0.010	-0.024*
		(0.106)		(0.055)		(0.032)		(0.016)	(0.014)
MicroXWinXpostElect		0.037		-0.100*		-0.115***		0.064***	0.019*
		(0.109)		(0.058)		(0.035)		(0.012)	(0.011)
Controls	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Adj_R2	0.064	0.208	0.011	0.126	0.066	0.120	0.023	0.057	0.024
N	55987	55987	55987	55987	55987	55987	106395	63862	63882

Micro to Macro Partisan Bias and Switch for All Elections (I)

MSC elections 2008, 2016, 2020; SCE elections 2016-2020

back

Partisan Bias, Sentiment, and Extrapolation - Additional Results (II)

	MSC Inflation 1y	MSC Gas Price 1y	MSC Inflation 5y	MSC Gas Price 5y	SCE Inflation	SCE Gas Price	SCE Food Price	SCE Rent price
Win	0.096	0.006	-0.054	-0.043	-0.029***	0.341***	0.464***	0.342***
	(0.186)	(0.273)	(0.075)	(0.066)	(0.011)	(0.065)	(0.114)	(0.049)
postElect	2.120***	1.485***	0.466***	-0.036***	2.780***	2.086***	1.650***	1.477***
	(0.001)	(0.069)	(0.002)	(0.011)	(0.006)	(0.084)	(0.108)	(0.189)
WinXpostElect	-1.409***	-1.105***	-0.270***	-0.304***	-1.924***	-1.401***	-1.139***	-1.018***
	(0.017)	(0.189)	(0.048)	(0.033)	(0.087)	(0.157)	(0.169)	(0.096)
Micro		0.015***		0.005***		0.127***	0.359***	0.266***
		(0.003)		(0.000)		(0.012)	(0.010)	(0.017)
MicroXpostElect		0.014***		0.004***		0.062***	0.029**	0.025
		(0.003)		(0.000)		(0.013)	(0.013)	(0.022)
MicroXWin		0.003		-0.000		-0.058***	-0.074***	-0.035***
		(0.003)		(0.000)		(0.007)	(0.013)	(0.004)
MicroXWinXpostElect		0.004		0.003***		0.029***	0.007	-0.026***
		(0.003)		(0.000)		(0.005)	(0.006)	(0.001)
Controls	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Adj. R^2	0.063	0.097	0.021	0.049	0.091	0.135	0.184	0.169
N	55046	33070	55522	41222	104155	90067	90258	90315

Micro to Macro Partisan Bias and Switch for All Elections (II)

MSC elections 2008, 2016, 2020; SCE elections 2016-2020

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